



Cambridge (CIE) IGCSE English Language



Your notes

Question 2: Short-Answer Questions

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Your notes

How to Answer Question 2: Short-Answer Questions

How to Answer Question 2: Short-Answer Questions

Paper 1: Reading is the compulsory exam in the CIE IGCSE, and CIE examiners recommend that you complete the questions in the order they are set. Question 2 is split into two tasks: a short-answer task (2a-c) and a language analysis task (2d). Both tasks will be based on **Text C** in your reading insert.

The following guide will provide you with the information you need to answer **Question 2: Short-answer questions** confidently.

Overview

For this task, you will respond to a series of sub-questions about Text C. These sub-questions will require answers of different lengths and test your understanding of the meaning of words and phrases used in Text C, as well as the effect they have on the reader. These sub-questions are worth 10 marks in total and are broken down as follows:

Question	What you are asked to do	Marks
2(a)	Identify a word or phrase from the text which suggests the same idea as the words underlined in the sub-questions	4
2(b)	Explain, <i>using your own words</i> , what a word or phrase underlined means	3
2(c)	Select one example from the section of text printed underneath the question, and use it to explain how the writer suggests something, <i>using your own words</i>	3

Breaking down the questions

Short-answer questions will be divided into seven sub-questions. It is important that you read each question carefully and highlight:

- The command words in each question (what you have to do)
- The focus of each question (what you are looking for in the text)
- How many marks each question is worth (this indicates how much you need to write)

For example (taken from the June 2022 exam paper):



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This reminds you which text you are working from

Question 2

Read Text C, *What it's like to be married to a future Ironman*, in the insert and then answer Questions 2(a)–(d) on this question paper.

(a) Identify a word or phrase from the text which suggests the same idea as the words underlined:

(i) The writer was slightly unsure that it was a good idea to publish their blog entry.

..... [1]

(ii) Her husband's training had little effect on the daily life of the family to begin with.

..... [1]

(iii) Fitting in bike rides to the family's weekend schedule was perfectly manageable.

..... [1]

(iv) The writer accepted grumpily that they hadn't changed their mind about Sam competing in the Ironman.

..... [1]

These are your instructions; read them carefully

Here are the marks. There is 1 mark per answer

You should highlight the underlined words and find this part of the text

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The instructions tell you that you have to write your answers in your own words

(b) Using your own words, explain what the writer means by each of the words underlined:

June was all about Ironman. Endless weekends with Sam gone until 5pm each day. After exercise he would need to sleep for an hour or so, thus he was technically gone for longer. I was desperate for us to go away and have a break from it.

- (i) endless [1]
- (ii) technically [1]
- (iii) desperate [1]

The part of the text is given so that you can read the words in context

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These instructions tell you to use only one example from the text below

(c) Use **one** example from the text below to explain how the writer suggests their feelings about Sam's approach to training for the Ironman event.

Use your own words in your explanation.

There was so much laundry ('different road conditions') so much extra food ('fuel') and so much gear (multiple pairs of goggles with different tints 'because you never know...')! Smiling understandingly, Sam assured me the next one will be cheaper. Next one?

.....

Remember, you are being tested on your ability to analyse how the writer shows their feelings, so you must explore the writer's craft: this means not just their use of language, but also the structure of the writing

This reminds you to write your answer using your own words

Three marks tells you that you should make three distinct points

[3]

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Steps to success

Following these steps will give you a strategy for answering this question effectively:

1. Read the question and **highlight**:

- The command words (what you are instructed to do)
- The focus of the question (the words or phrases you have to look for in the text)
- When highlighting, take note of the marks given for each sub-question

2. Scan Text C and highlight the evidence that answers the question, or the words or phrases you need to explain:

- Remember that there may be more than one answer - make sure your answer provides what the question instructions have asked for



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3. Write your answers according to the question instructions:

- If the question asks you to explain each of the words underlined, make sure that you give an answer for each one
- If the question asks you to use your own words, then make sure you do not repeat words from the text
- Check how many marks are awarded for each question, and tailor your answers accordingly:
 - For Question 2(c), 3 marks tells you that you should make three distinct points

4. For Question 2(c), examiners are looking for you to select an appropriate example and provide a comprehensive explanation which shows that you understand how the writer gets their message or point across:

- For example, you might consider the meanings of particular phrases and why the writer has chosen to use them
- You might wish to consider why the writer has punctuated a phrase or sentence in a certain way
- Above all, you need to read between the lines to consider what the writer really means

You are advised to spend no more than 15 minutes on this question (including reading time).

Exam tips

- Read the command words and the paragraph references in the instructions carefully
- Do not write overly long explanations or answers in your own words where they are not required:
 - Equally, make sure you do not just repeat the language of the text in answers where your own words are required
 - It is made clear in the task instructions when you should write your answers using your own words
- Avoid adding additional unnecessary material and/or extra guesses in your answers:
 - In Question 2(a)(i-v), you only need to write a word or phrase as your answer – this means you do not need to copy out the whole of the sentence
 - In Question 2(b)(i-iii), you have to consider the precise meaning of each word in the context in which they have been used
 - Avoid repeating the word itself in your explanation
 - In Question 2(c), make sure you select just one example and explain its meaning first in context:
 - You can then go on to explore what this suggests
 - Make sure you make three distinct points about your chosen example

- Remember, you are being tested on your ability to analyse how the writer shows their feelings, so you must explore the writer's craft:

- This means not just their use of language, but also the structure of the writing

The full June 2022 exam paper is available [here](#).

For more advice on how to apply the skills required for success in this question, please see our [Question 2 skills: Synonyms](#) revision notes. For model answers to these questions, please see [Question 2 short-answer questions: Model answers](#).



Your notes



Your notes

Question 2 Skills: Synonyms

Question 2 Skills: Synonyms

Question 2 tests you on your ability to understand the explicit and implied meanings of words and phrases in a text (in context). You will be asked to identify a word or phrase in the text which corresponds to the words that are underlined, and to explain what specific words mean in context. This means you need to have an understanding of synonyms.

What are synonyms?

Synonyms are words or phrases that mean exactly or nearly the same as another word or phrase. For example, “tiny” is a synonym of “small”, and “excellent” is a synonym of “fantastic”. Developing your knowledge of synonyms can help you expand your vocabulary and your use of more sophisticated words and phrases. This can be a useful life skill, as instead of applying for a “job”, you can be applying for a “position”, or instead of saying “sorry” you could be offering an “apology”.

How to use synonyms in context

A **thesaurus** is a tool which can help you find synonyms for particular words, and there may be lots to choose from. However, it is important that any synonym you choose means the same in context as the original word or phrase.

For example, if we take the word “dying”. The literal meaning of this word is something that is reaching the end of its life. But in the exam, you might be asked to explain what the writer means by the word “dying” in a sentence such as:

On the other side, there was a streetlamp with a dying bulb.

Here, the examiner would be looking for an explanation of the word “dying” appropriate to the context in which it has been used. So, in this case, the bulb is becoming fainter and dimmer, so the appropriate synonyms would be “fading” or “dimming”.

This is why it is always important to consider the context in which a word or phrase has been used in order to explain it.



Your notes

Question 2 Short-Answer Questions: Model Answers

Question 2 Short-Answer Questions: Model Answers

Question 2 is split into two tasks: a short-answer task and a language analysis task. Both tasks will be based on Text C in your reading insert, and are designed to test your ability to select and interpret what you read appropriately.

The following guide will demonstrate how to answer the Question 2: Short-answer questions from the June 2022 exam paper.

Text C (June 2022)

The following is Text C taken from the June 2022 exam paper. It is about a writer's experience of supporting her husband's training to compete in an endurance athletics event, and contains both the explicit and implicit information you will need in order to answer the questions.

Text C: What it's like to be married to a future Ironman

In this blog post the writer looks back on their husband's preparations to compete in an Ironman event.

I'm a little hesitant to publish this because there's a risk that I'll just be moaning and I'll come across as whiny, but it's information I wish someone had given me before we signed up for the whole Ironman thing.

My husband, Sam, started training in January for Ironman Canada at the end of July. He got himself an expert coach and monthly training plans. I felt reassured this meant he might at least survive the 3.86 km swim, a 180.25 km bicycle ride and a marathon (42.20 km) run, raced in that order.

5

His training ramped up as you'd expect. Initially, it didn't really impact our lives too much. If anything, it was a good thing. Now, we were both training for things – it felt like a real partnership as we plotted our weekends to give us time to train and time together as a family. It was fun. If we went away, we had to fit his bike ride of 1–3 hours into the weekend but that was totally do-able. We've a pool where we live which really helped – not having to drive to/from water at least saved travelling time.

10

By May he was training early and most of both weekend mornings. Being honest, I resented that. I agreed sullenly, yes, I still wanted him to do the Ironman, and no, I didn't expect him to drop out. I was just fed up with his absences.

15

June was all about Ironman. Endless weekends with Sam gone until 5pm each day. After exercise he would need to sleep for an hour or so, thus he was technically gone for longer. I was desperate for us to go away and have a break from it.



I tried to book a weekend camping but abandoned it. We would have spent the whole time fitting Sam's training around what we were doing, and it wasn't worth it. That year the kids didn't go camping at all. 20

My own freedom to run was curtailed. Saturdays became all about childcare. I only managed one Saturday trail-run with the girls from April onwards and that was thanks to wonderful friends who got up at 6.45 on a Saturday to watch my son. I got fed up with not being able to say yes to invitations. 25

We didn't do any family hiking for months. Sam justifiably didn't want to hike after exercising.

There was so much laundry ('different road conditions') so much extra food ('fuel') and so much gear (multiple pairs of goggles with different tints 'because you never know...')! Smiling understandingly, Sam assured me the next one will be cheaper. Next one? 30

'Because it's there,' I'd snarl to anyone who dared question why any sane mortal would tackle an Ironman. I enjoyed mercilessly shaming his less-than-supportive business partner into recognising the potentially boundless benefits of Sam's well-publicised adventure for their newly-established, fledgling travel company. A flurry of online articles described me as 'a runner married to a triathlete' – it took me a few moments to recognise our family and beam with immeasurable pride. 35

Our son missed having Dad around at the weekends, especially if he woke up after Sam had left to train on a Saturday when sometimes there were tears. But he got used to the different dynamic. He was given an 'Ironman' superhero toy as a birthday gift by some relatives and immediately started making it swim, bike and run! The poor child thinks that this is how normal families operate. 40

Having said all that, watching Sam emerge god-like from the water, power past us on his bike and rocket down the finishing chute, head held high as our kids cheered with the crowd – utterly incredible and intoxicating, one of life's rare pinnacles of perfection. It had been an epic journey for all of us. I'm so glad we did it. And next year? Well yes, it's my turn... 45

Question 2(a–c) model answers

Question 2(a) is broken down into four sub-questions, and will ask you to identify a word or phrase from the text which suggests the same idea as the words underlined.

When looking for words or phrases in the text that suggest the same as the words underlined in the question, it is important to look for what other clues you are given in the text.

For example:



Your notes

You need to identify a word or phrase that suggests the same as: "The writer was slightly unsure that it was a good idea to publish her blog entry." The word "publish" is a clue to look for in the text – this then leads you to the answer: "a little hesitant"

Text C: What it's like to be married to a future Ironman

In this blog post the writer looks back on their husband's preparations to compete in an Ironman event.

I'm a little hesitant to publish this because there's a risk that I'll just be moaning and I'll come across as whiny, but it's information I wish someone had given me before we signed up for the whole Ironman thing.

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Question 2(b) will ask you to explain, in your own words, what the writer means by certain words underlined in the text. You should therefore find and highlight the words in the text, and then explain their meaning in context. For example:



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Here, the word "endless" is referring to the weekends the speaker spends on her own, so in this context it means that the weekend seemed to last forever

June was all about Ironman. Endless weekends with Sam gone until 5pm each day. After exercise, he would need to sleep for an hour or so, thus he was technically gone for longer. I was desperate for us to go away and have a break from it.

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Question 2(c) will ask you to choose one example from the text to explain how the writer conveys something to the reader. For this question, again locate the passage in the context of the whole text. Make sure, in your answer, that it is clear which example from the text you are using, and then make three separate points about it. Do not waste time writing in long paragraphs when three short sentences will do.



Your notes

This question asks you to choose one example from the text to explain how the writer suggests their feelings about Sam's approach to training for the Ironman event

As this is a 3-mark question, you need to make three separate points about the same example

There was so much laundry ('different road conditions') so much extra food ('fuel') and so much gear (multiple pairs of goggles with different tints 'because you never know...')! Smiling understandingly, Sam assured me the next one will be cheaper. Next one?

1. The fact that he "assured" her suggests she had voiced some concerns about the impact of training on family life

3. The final rhetorical question implies dismay that he is thinking of doing it again

2. The use of a statement here, followed by a rhetorical question, suggests the speaker is feeling surprised that Sam wants to do another event

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Summary

- Remember to read each sub-question carefully and highlight:
 - What you have to do
 - What you have to look for in the text (the focus of the question)
- Pay attention to the number of marks awarded for each sub-question and write your answers accordingly
- Make sure you find and highlight the words and phrases in the text:
 - This will ensure that you are explaining them in the correct context
- If the question asks you to use your own words, *most* of your answer needs to be in your own words; you must not just copy from the text

- These are short-answer questions, so do not waste time writing paragraphs when short sentences will do:
 - Writing more will not get you more marks - the examiner can only award the amount of marks allocated to each sub-question

The full June 2022 exam paper is available [here](#).



Your notes